Making Great Decisions in Times of Uncertainty

Bridging the gap between formulation and implementation.

Facilitator: Yagev Ben Itzhak

Workshop Topics

1 Are you a good decision maker?

2 What is a good decision?

3 Alone or with my team?

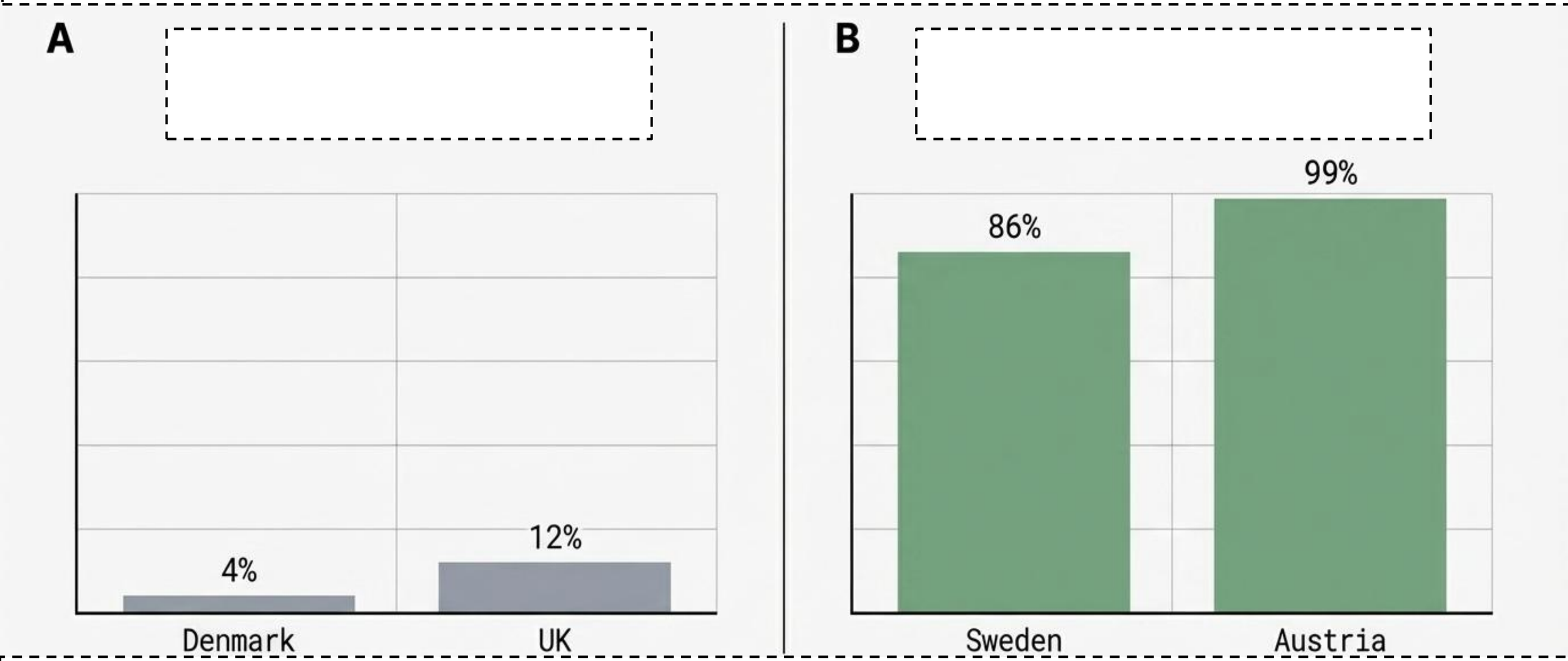
4 Types of Problems (Simple, Complex, Complicated, Chaotic)

5 Decision vs. Implementation

6 What to do when things constantly change? Decisions in an Uncertain environment

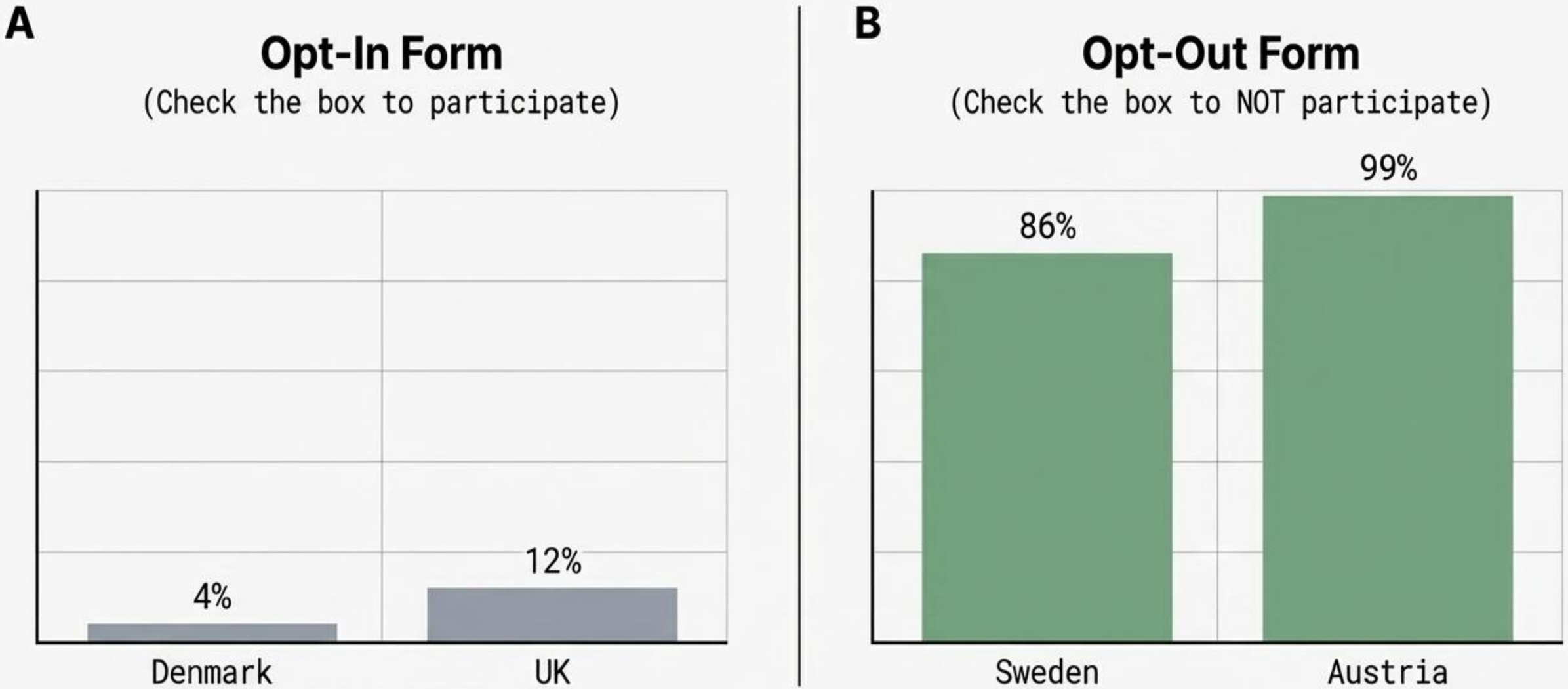
1 Are you a good decision maker?

On a scale of 1-10 how good a decision maker are you?



Source: DR Yossi Yasur

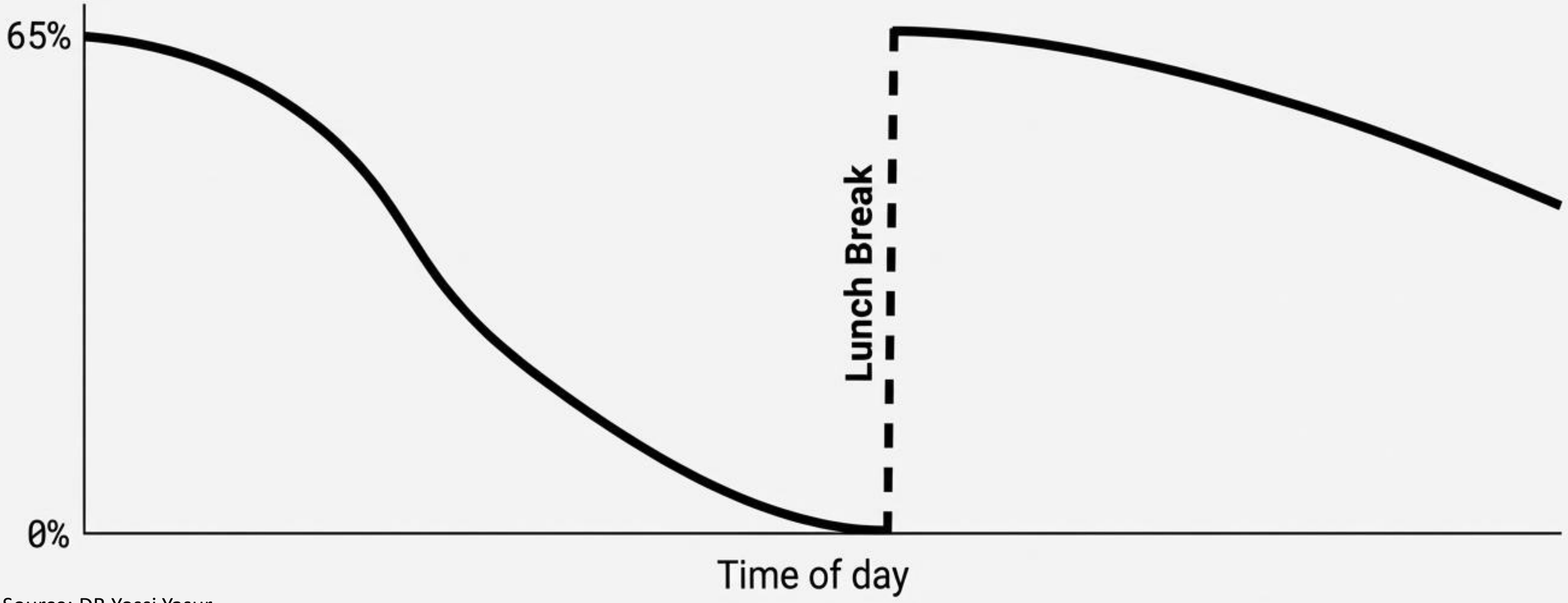
The Architect of the Form Makes the Decision



In complex decisions, humans overwhelmingly choose to do nothing—accepting whatever default the system designer chose for them.

Source: DR Yossi Yasur

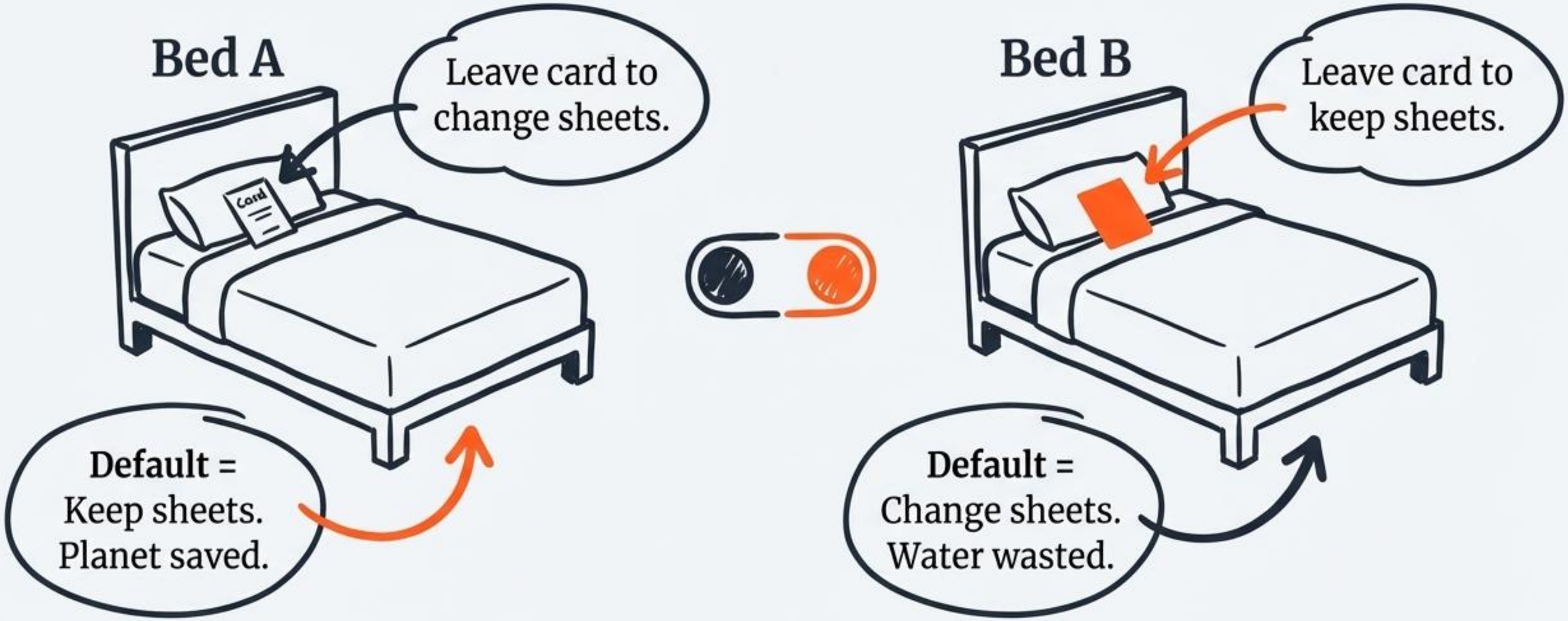
Justice is Dictated by Blood Sugar



Source: DR Yossi Yasur

Decision fatigue leads to the safest, easiest option (denying parole).
Basic biology overrides objective professional judgment.

He Who Controls the Default Controls the World



Changing the wording doesn't change your options. It changes your passive default. We will almost always choose the path of least resistance.

Source: DR Yossi Yasur

Putting a Price on Guilt

The Social Norm

Parents arrive late → Social guilt restrains behavior.

The Market Norm

Daycare introduces a financial fine -> Tardiness increases drastically.

Source: DR Yossi Yasur

Introducing a financial penalty removes the moral penalty. People treat the fine as a purchased service rather than a social transgression.

The Two Types of Decisions

Active Decisions

Requires actual cognitive effort. Forces change. Invites the terrifying possibility of regret.

Passive Decisions

The Status Quo. Happens completely automatically when we do absolutely nothing. The brain's absolute favorite place to be.

Source: DR Yossi Yasur

The Brain Glitch Matrix

These irrational moments aren't random accidents. Our cognitive errors are highly systematic and easily categorized.

Whether misjudging probability out of fear, or value out of ego, the underlying operating system is running the exact same buggy code.

	Scale & Numbers	Memory & Imagery
Driven by Ego	Small sample size $20 relative misery	Perfectionism & Options
Driven by Fear	Probability vs. Profile	Vivid, rare imagery

Any conclusions from these examples?

Source: DR Yossi Yasur

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In complex situations, you cannot analyze your way to the answer

Framework 1: The Cynefin Framework

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WHAT TYPE OF PROBLEM ARE YOU TRYING TO SOLVE?

In complex situations, you cannot analyze your way to the answer

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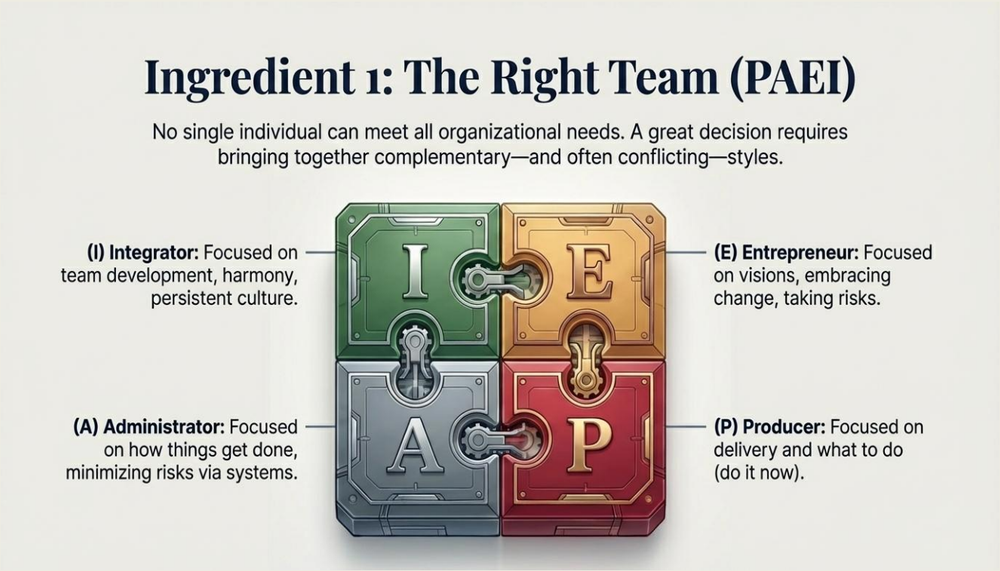
Framework 1: The Cynefin Framework

When do I need a team?



Source: DR Ichak Adizes

Ingredient 1: The Right Team (PAEI)

No single individual can meet all organizational needs. A great decision requires bringing together complementary—and often conflicting—styles.

(I) Integrator: Focused on team development, harmony, persistent culture.

(E) Entrepreneur: Focused on visions, embracing change, taking risks.

(A) Administrator: Focused on how things get done, minimizing risks via systems.

(P) Producer: Focused on delivery and what to do (do it now).

Source: DR Ichak Adizes

The Execution Gap

The primary reason strategic initiatives fail is simple: formulation is separated from implementation.

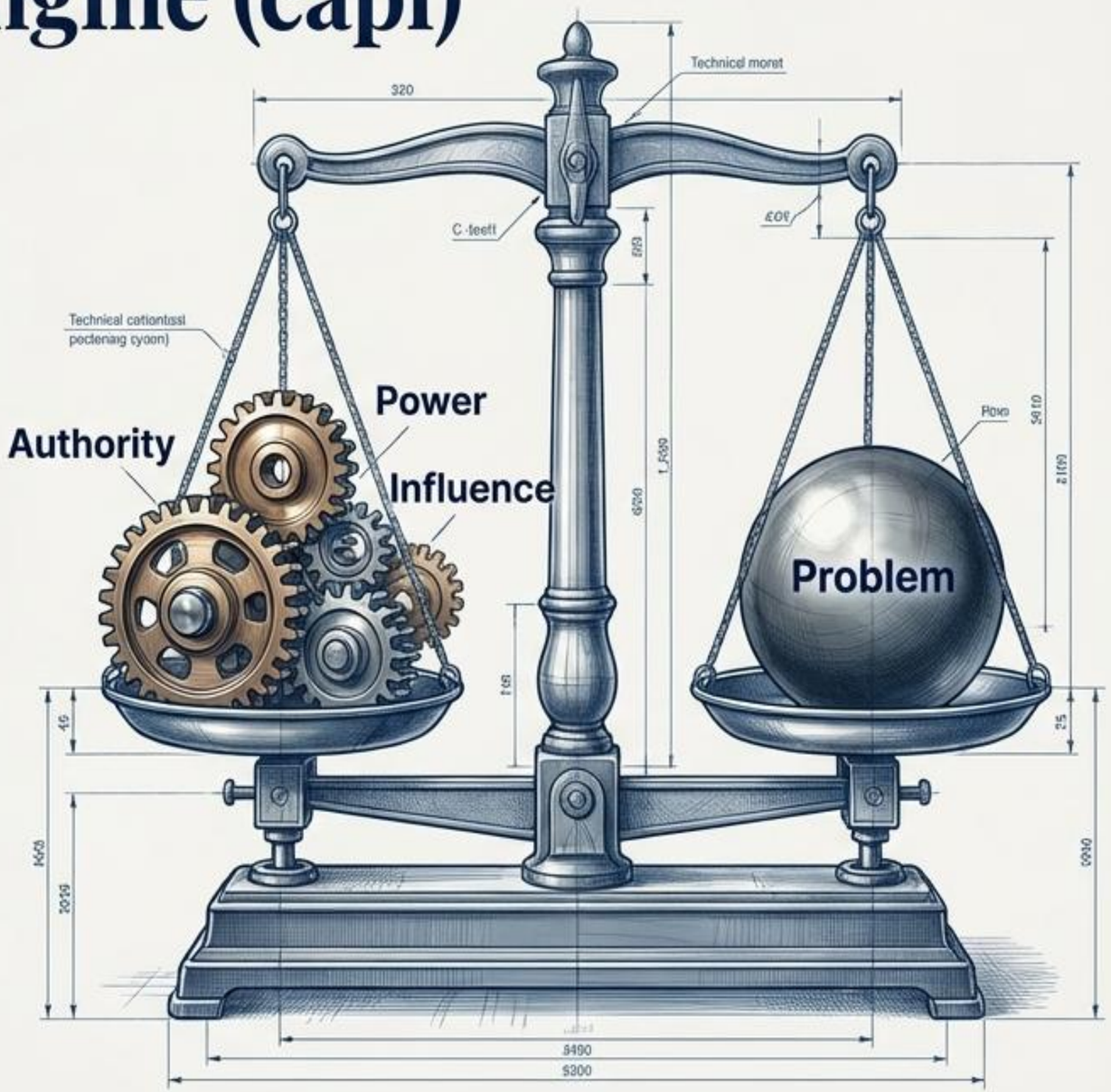
The Golden Rule: Those who make the decision must be able to implement it.

Ingredient 2: The Right Engine (capi)

The team must hold coalesced authority, power, and influence.

If the problem is larger than the team's combined capi, the decision will fail.

The team must adjust its composition until their capability matches the challenge.



The Golden Equation: capi = problem

Source: DR Ichak Adizes

The Operating Rule: Democraship

How to harness the inevitable conflict?

Absolute Democracy

During the formulation of the decision. Disagreement is actively encouraged to find the best path.

Absolute Dictatorship

During the implementation. Debate is shut down to ensure pristine execution.

The 70% Rule

Question for the room: How much information do you usually wait for before making a decision?

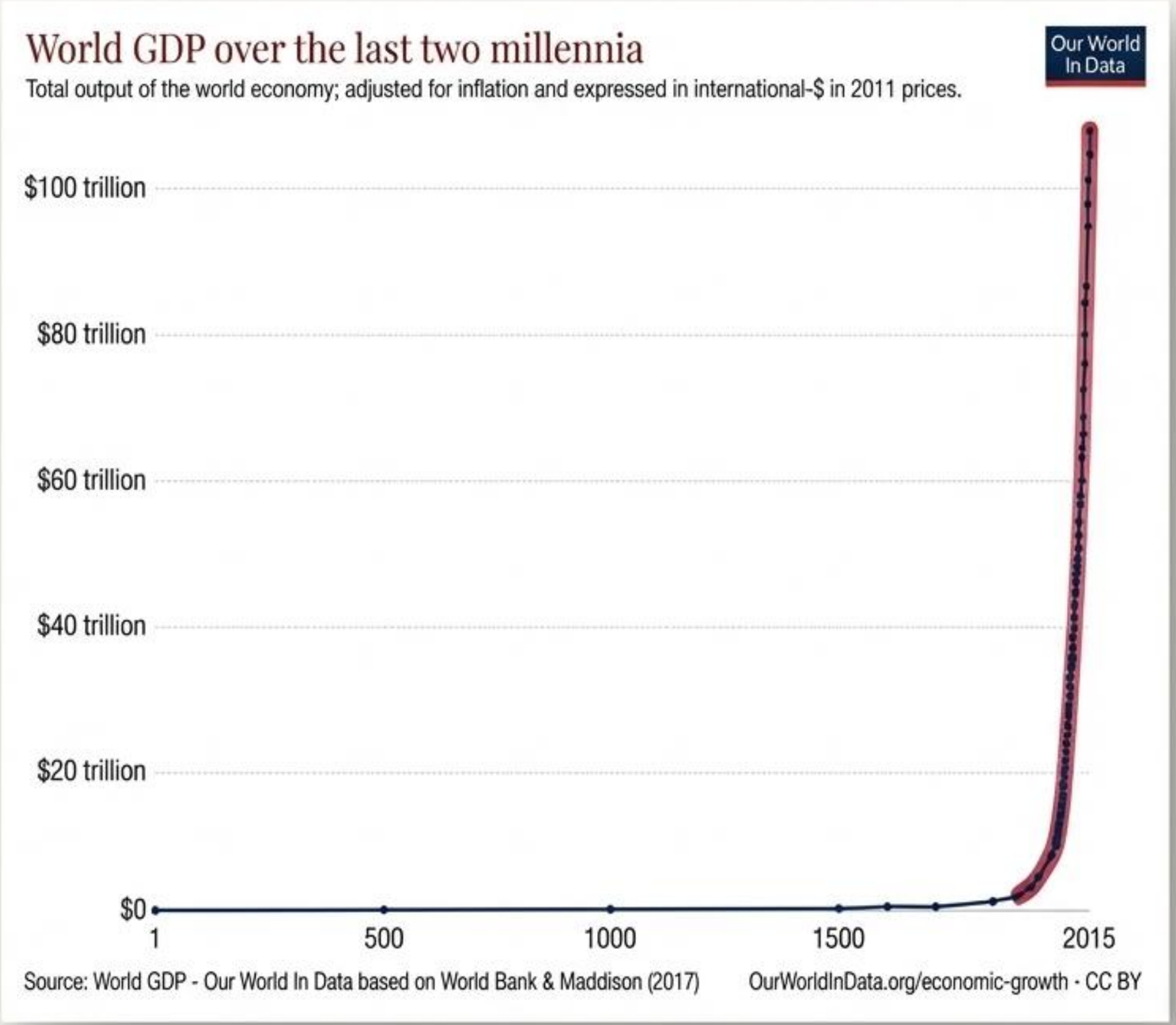
The Bezos Heuristic:

- Make most decisions when you have 70% of the information.
- Type 1 Decisions: Irreversible (Proceed with caution).
- Type 2 Decisions: Reversible (Move fast, over-analyzing is a trap).

What happens when leaders wait for 100%? They lose the opportunity.

Everything looks like a hockey stick

- ✓ Market Digitalization & Globalization
- ✓ Technology & AI trends
- ✓ Climate



Fast Assessment
Fast Learning
Fast Execution

Fast Assessment: Signal vs. Noise

Most bad decisions are not dut due to a lack of intelligence, but ignored signals or distractions by noise.

Daily Assessment Checklist

1. What new inputs do I have?
2. What opportunities or risks do they create?
3. Does this change my plan?
4. What to add, what to drop?
5. Who does what?

Activity Prompt: **List 3 real signals in your industry you should monitor weekly.**

Engineering hindsight and foresight

Tool 1: A.A.R. (After Action Review)

- Postmortem of critical events.
- **Ask: What went well? What can be improved? What do we do differently tomorrow morning?**

Tool 2: B.E.R. (Before Action Review) / Pre-Mortem

- Breakout Scenario: It is 12 months from now and the decision you are postponing has failed completely.
- **Question: What went wrong?**

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Decision Autopsy Exercise

Breakout: think about a bad decision you made.

Discuss:

What signals did you ignore?

What assumptions were wrong?

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Pre-Mortem Exercise

Scenario:

It is 12 months from now and this decision failed.

Question:

What went wrong?

This dramatically improves decision quality.

Fast Execution

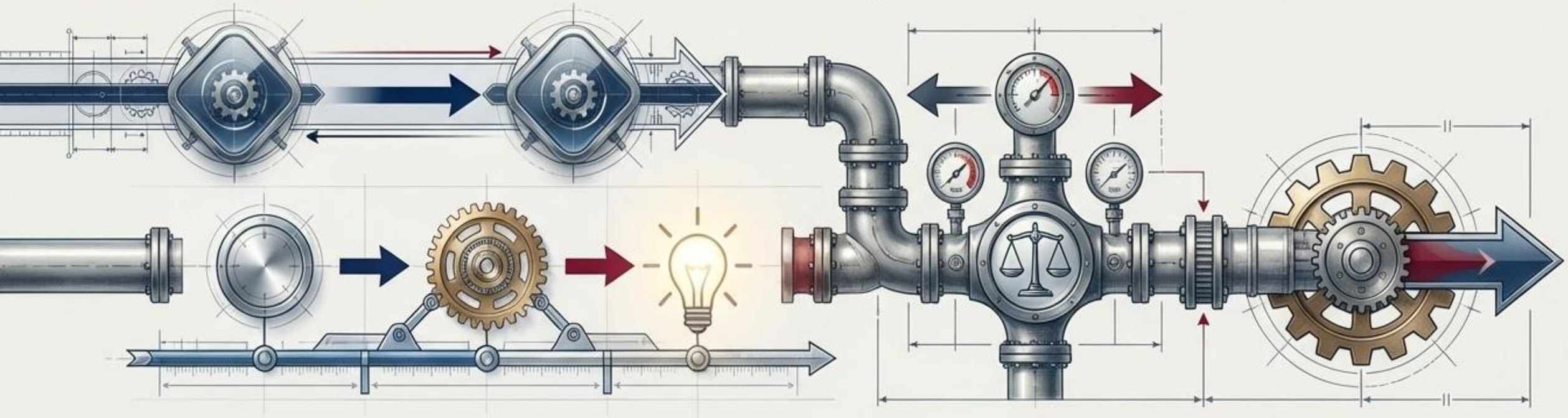
The 8 Stages of Team Decision-Making

Phase 1: Gathering (Defreeze & Accumulate)

Administrators thrive here.

Phase 3: Stress-Testing (Accommodate & Consensus)

Integrators are vital.



Phase 2: Processing

(Deliberate, Incubate, Illuminate)

Entrepreneurs shine.

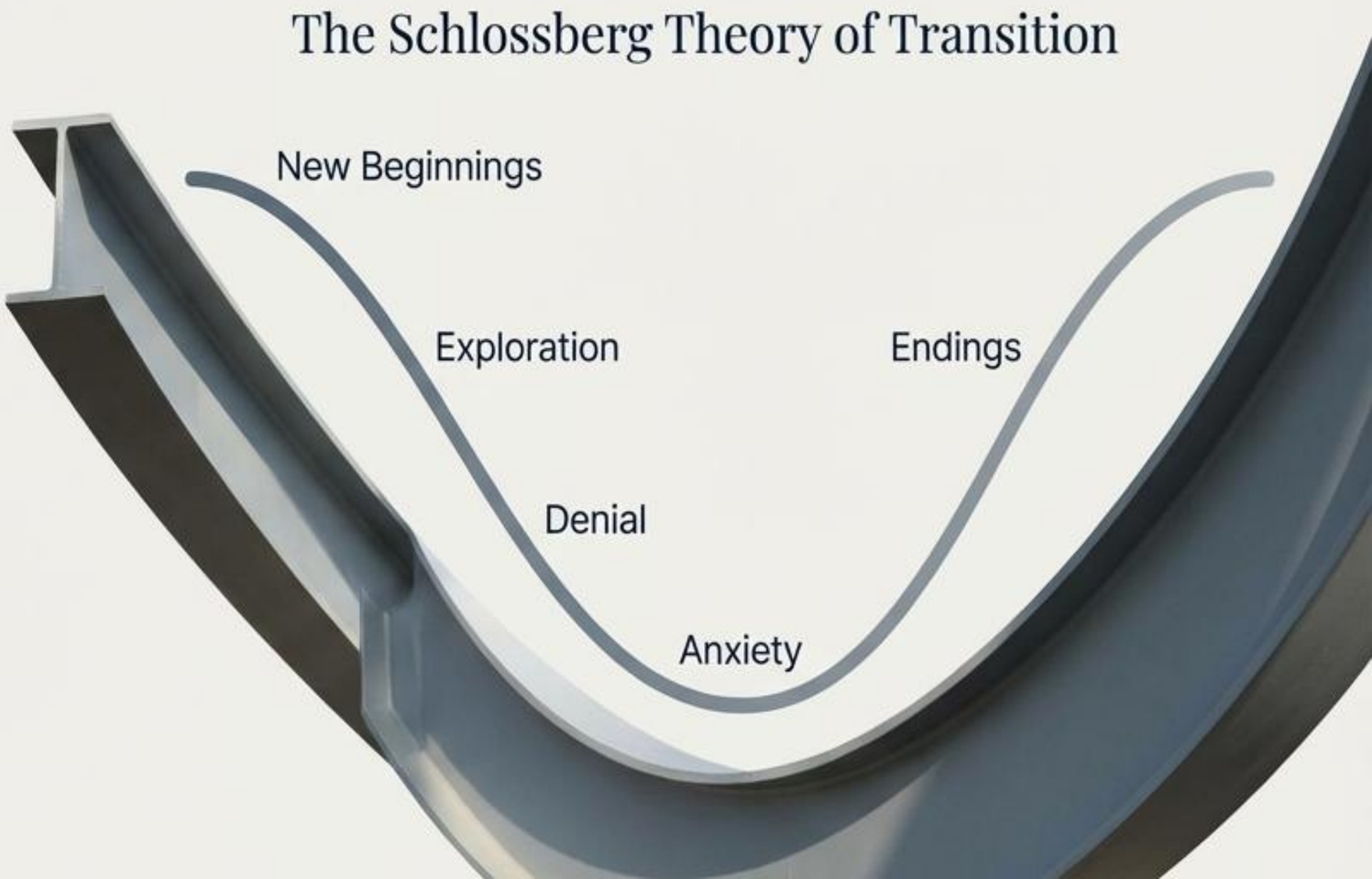
Phase 4: Executing

(Finalize & Reinforce)

Producers push for action.

Source: DR Ichak Adizes

People don’t resist change; they resist being changed.



- Change creates conflict.
- To change is to lose control.
- Change requires ‘getting your hands dirty’ and making tough choices.

Tactical Exercise: Stakeholder Mapping

Think about the change initiative you are leading.
Who will resist your decision?

1. Supporters

2. Neutrals

3. Resistors

Discussion Question: What does each group care about? What are the potential sources of resistance and the best ways to deal with them?

The 3 Rules of Adar Cohen

How to navigate the hardest conversations.

1 Joining: “Move towards the conflict”
(Show empathy, keep the big picture, use small gestures)

2 “You don’t know anything”
(And even if you do, pretend you don’t. Ask & Listen)

3 Keep Quiet
(Allow the silence to do the heavy lifting)

Source: Adar Cohen – Ted Talk

Golden Rules for Managing Resistance

The DOs:

- Involve people early to go through the cycle together.
- Assume they mean well, even though they disagree.
- Rise above the zero-sum game to find a win-win situation.

The DON'Ts:

- Don't ignore questions or dismiss fears.
- Don't send mixed messages or withhold information.
- Don't act more concerned about your own welfare.

> "Communication is a drip irrigation system: Messages must be repeated, in the right chunks, by the right person, in a supportive setting."

The Ultimate Output: Mutual Trust and Respect

A flawless decision process does more than solve business problems.
By combining the right team (PAEI), the right engine (capi), and the right process (Democraship & 8 Stages), inevitable organizational conflict becomes constructive.
The result is a persistent culture of Mutual Trust and Respect—ensuring the organization can sustain high performance through accelerating change.

Source: DR Ichak Adizes

Building your Capability

What is one concrete tool you will add to your leadership toolbox tomorrow morning?